



BE READY.

September to Christmas

First half of the season: the guide

How your program works: schedule, how the sessions run, progression and the rules to know.

Duration

18 semaines

Frequency

2 sessions per week

Session

30 to 40 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Before you start

During the season, your club already takes care of a large part of your training load. The aim of this program is not to add more, but to **maintain and build on** what you have built: without extra work, strength and explosiveness fade over the weeks of competition. A single strength session a week is enough to keep the summer's gains for 12 weeks, whereas one session every two weeks is not (Rønnestad et al., 2011): so never skip session 1 two weeks in a row.

Didn't do a pre-season? Do weeks 1 and 2 one level below yours, while your body gets used to it again.

You received	What it is for
This guide	Understanding the program: how it works, schedule, progression, rules
Your sessions	All your sessions written out in full, in order, with the warm-up, your goal or goals, core work, the cool-down and an illustrated sheet for every exercise
Running option (if chosen)	Your extra running sessions

On training day, all you need is the "Your sessions" document: everything is in it, from the warm-up to the cool-down. This guide is for understanding the program: read it once in full before you start.

Equipment

Your program is built for the gym: dumbbells, barbell, bench, cables, plyo box, medicine ball. For running, use a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself) if your gym has one; otherwise each sheet gives an alternative (assault bike, rowing machine).

Choosing your level

Level	Who it is for	In the sessions
Level 1	You are a beginner: little or no physical preparation so far	Lowest number of sets, "easier" versions
Level 2	You have some foundations: a season of strength training or physical preparation	Middle number of sets
Level 3	You are experienced: several seasons of regular training	Highest number of sets, advanced versions

In your sessions, "2-4 × 8" means 2 sets (level 1), 3 sets (level 2) or 4 sets (level 3) of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.

Setting the intensity: the effort scale

Score	How it feels	Guide
5-6	Easy to moderate	You could still do 4 to 5 more reps
7-8	Hard but controlled	You have 2 to 3 reps left in reserve
9	Very hard	Only one more rep possible
10	Maximal	To avoid in this program

Under 15 (girls) or 16 (boys)

The program is the same, with a few rules so that the loads stay suited to your age:

- **No heavy sets** of 1 to 5 reps: take a load you could lift 10 to 12 times, and do 6 to 8.
- **Always keep at least 3 reps in reserve:** never a set to failure.
- **Technique before weight:** only add load if the movement stays perfect from the start to the end of the set.
- **The barbell only with an adult** who knows the movement (coach, trainer, trained parent).
- Jumps, sprints and prevention do not change.
- At the gym, every loaded exercise shows its version for your age, under "Under 15 (girls) or 16 (boys)".

Sharp pain, a joint giving way, dizziness: stop the exercise. Discomfort that lasts more than 48 hours or comes back every session must be seen by a health professional.

Your week around the match

Your 2 sessions go **far from the match**: session 1 (the more demanding one) at least 3 days before, session 2 (lighter) no later than 2 days before. Never the day before a match.

Match on Saturday

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
Rest	Session 1	Club	Session 2	Club	Rest or light club session	MATCH

Match on Sunday

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
Rest	Session 1	Club	Session 2	Club	Rest	MATCH

- Session 1 can be done on the same day as a club practice, ideally in the morning or at the end of practice, if you feel good.
- **Week with two matches:** only do session 2, in a short version.
- **Heavy fatigue or a minor injury:** skip the session, the season is long.

- No match this weekend: do both sessions as usual.

How a session works

Step	Duration	What it is for
1. Warm-up	8 min	Prepare the body and reduce the risk of injury: the balance and landing work of the warm-up is part of the prevention.
2. First block	10-12 min	Your first goal. Explosiveness and Power always come first.
3. Second block	10-12 min	Your second goal. If you chose a single goal, this block works it from another angle.
4. Core and prevention	5 min	Hamstrings, adductors and shoulders, heavily used in handball.
5. Cool-down	3-5 min	Walking and light stretches.

What the studies say: a warm-up routine with balance and landings almost halved knee and ankle injuries in young handball players (Olsen et al., BMJ, 2005). The Copenhagen plank reduced adductor problems by 41% (Harøy et al., BJSM, 2019). A shoulder prevention program done 3 times a week reduced shoulder problems by 28% (Andersson et al., BJSM, 2017).

The shoulder routine (optional)

To reach 3 times a week, add the **10-minute shoulder routine** (in your sessions, after session 2) on a third day: for instance before club training, at the end of your warm-up.

The 18 weeks

Weeks	Block	What we are after	Effort
1 to 3, 4 lighter	Into the season	Keep the summer's strength as games start again	6-7
5 to 7, 8 lighter	Maintain with intensity	Few sets, heavy and fast	7-8
9 to 11, 12 lighter	Keep your level	Heavy then fast contrast, short sprints	7-8
13 to 15, 16 lighter	Before the break	Freshness for the last games	7
17	Break	Complete rest	-
18	Break	3 short sessions to prepare the restart	6-7

Lighter weeks: one set less on every exercise. The sessions change with each block: you will find them in order in the "Your sessions" document.

Breaks: one week of rest, one week of work

Over a 2-week break, the **first week is a real week of rest**, and the **second a week of work** to be ready for the restart. That is the case at Christmas (weeks 17 and 18), and in the autumn holidays if your league stops (weeks 8 and 9: week 8 resting, week 9 with the 3 break sessions).

Golden rule in season: when in doubt between doing more or less, do less. Arriving fresh for the match matters more than the session.

Tracking your sessions

Date	Session	Days before the match	Perceived effort (/10)	How you feel today (/5)

- How you feel today at 1 or 2 out of 5: only do the core and mobility work, or rest.
- Heavy legs on match day two weeks in a row: move session 1 one day earlier, or drop a set.

What next?

In January, the **second half of the season** takes over, from the restart to the June finals, with the same goals: each part prepares the next.

A question about the program? Just reply to the email that sent you this document.